



T-storm, shower 87/68 • Tomorrow: Rain, t-storm 73/65 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

SATURDAY, MAY 3, 2025 • \$4

Minerals deal leaves Russians worried

Some elites see possible U.S. tilt toward Kyiv closing a key window

BY CATHERINE BELTON

Concern is growing in Moscow that Russia could lose its edge in talks with the United States over the Ukraine war now that Kyiv has finally signed an economic partnership agreement giving Washington preferential access to future Ukrainian mineral deals.

Russian officials poured scorn on the agreement this week, with one senator, Alexei Pushkov saying it represented “another major step toward the colonization of Ukraine.” Alexei Chepa, deputy head of the parliament’s international affairs committee, echoed him, saying the deal had further increased Ukraine’s dependency on the U.S.

“The deal in essence has turned Ukraine into a mineral colony,” he told Russian reporters.

But behind the scenes, nervousness is rising among the Russian elite that the deal could represent a new alignment between the U.S. and Ukraine that could close a window of opportunity for Russia to secure a peace deal on advantageous terms.

The arrival of the Trump administration had brought a dramatic shift in the U.S. approach to the conflict, with personal phone calls between President Donald Trump and Russian President Vladimir Putin, as well as numerous statements by U.S. envoy Steve Witkoff that leaned more toward the Russian view of the conflict. Trump had also been critical of generous U.S. military

SEE RUSSIA ON A12

A tinderbox in Kashmir



ADNAN ABDI/REUTERS

Muslims offer Friday prayer in Srinagar, the capital of Indian-administered Kashmir. India has vowed to punish Pakistan after an April 22 massacre left 26 tourists dead, mostly Hindu men, a charge Islamabad strongly denies. The nuclear-armed rivals have expelled each other’s diplomats and citizens, ordered the border shut and closed their airspace to each other. Pakistan’s prime minister met Friday with envoys from Gulf allies, seeking to defuse tensions.

President goes after funding for ‘biased’ NPR, PBS

BY SCOTT NOVER, HERB SCRIBNER AND FRANCES VINALL

President Donald Trump’s executive order seeking to end federal funding for NPR and PBS — because of news coverage he called “biased and partisan” — triggered a fierce backlash from public broadcasters that appears poised to expand the White House’s larger legal battleground with the me-

Public broadcasters prepare to contest ‘blatantly unlawful’ order

dia industry.

Issued Thursday night, the order instructs the congressionally chartered Corporation for Public Broadcasting to cut off direct

funding to the venerable public media giants — producers of long-running news shows such as “All Things Considered” and “PBS NewsHour” — as well as any grants to local stations that might underwrite the national broadcasters’ programming.

PBS president and chief executive Paula Kerger said her organization was “exploring all options” to assist its member stations and challenge what she called a “bla-

tantly unlawful” move that “threatens our ability to serve the American public with educational programming, as we have for the past 50-plus years.” NPR vowed to “vigorously defend our right to provide essential news, information and life-saving services to the American public.”

SEE NPR ON A4

Agency turmoil: Cuts spark crisis at National Science Foundation. A7

As Musk departs DOGE, anger follows him out

To liberals who once saw him as an ally, he now embodies the ‘oligarchy’

BY MAEVE RESTON

LOS ANGELES — The moment that crystallized the ethos of Elon Musk for Janet Yoshitake, 71, was when the CEO of SpaceX and Tesla told podcaster Joe Rogan that the “fundamental weakness of Western civilization is empathy.”

For Joel Morin, a 67-year-old self-described “cable guy” from San Diego, it was Musk’s decision to pace the stage in sunglasses at the Conservative Political Action Conference throttling a chain saw “while putting tens of thousands of Americans out of work just to enrich himself.”

Meta Valentic, a Democrat from Culver City, California, who did not want to give her age, said she can no longer listen to Musk’s voice because it makes her feel physically ill. She is most angered by what she describes as Musk’s “hypocrisy” as he has slashed government services as a special adviser to President Donald Trump without acknowledging how he has relied on government largesse and policies to build his own empires.

“He made his money off the backs of all of us,” she said, referring to Musk’s reliance on at

least \$38 billion in government contracts, loans, subsidies and tax credits for his businesses, according to a Washington Post analysis. “He may think that we don’t need to help the rest of the world, but he’s from the rest of the world — and we sure helped him.”

Amid collapsing popularity, Musk told investors April 22 that he will step back from overseeing his government cost-cutting creation, the U.S. DOGE Service, also known as the Department of Government Efficiency. The decision followed a period in which Tesla’s profits plunged by 71 percent compared with the first quarter of 2024 and he had become the regular butt of jokes on “Saturday Night Live” and on his own social media site, X. When he formally leaves his government post, which is expected to be in May, it will be a moment of celebration for the thousands of voters like Yoshitake, Morin and Valentic, who all played bit parts in Musk’s troubles by protesting his influence in the streets and online.

During his short stint in government service, Musk became a singular object of loathing for many Democrats and independents. As his young team at the U.S. DOGE Service abruptly canceled grants and cut thousands of jobs at federal agencies with

SEE MUSK ON A14

Democrats: Trump backlash could help the party’s brand problem. A4



MICHAEL SWENSEN/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Where horses heal the broken

At a Kentucky farm, a recovery program pairs addicts with four-legged athletes

BY CHUCK CULPEPPER IN NICHOLASVILLE, KY.

John Bowman guides a young foal out of a paddock at Taylor Made Farm.

From this courthouse in the commonwealth of Kentucky — that foremost American harbor of the uncanny 5,000-year relationship between humans and horses, not to mention the host of another Kentucky Derby on Saturday — this defendant who had never really touched a racehorse before June 2023 told of what had happened since he began working with them routinely. It had rearranged his life and pro-

SEE RECOVERY ON A8

Kentucky Derby: Neil Greenberg breaks down the 151st running. D1

Trump takes ax to 2026 budget

SEEKS \$163 BILLION IN FEDERAL CUTS

Health, climate targeted; defense, DHS would rise

BY JEFF STEIN AND JACOB BOGAGE

The White House released a partial budget proposal Friday calling for \$163 billion in cuts to federal spending in the next fiscal year, pushing reductions to health care, education and many other government programs while boosting spending on defense and homeland security.

The White House’s 2026 fiscal budget plan would codify for next year many of the spending cuts already unilaterally implemented this year by President Donald Trump or billionaire Elon Musk’s U.S. DOGE Service. The administration has struggled to persuade Republicans in Congress to enshrine even a small portion of those cuts into law, and the courts have also ordered the White House to resume much of the spending, leaving the fate of the changes unclear for now.

The \$163 billion in requested cuts amount to nearly 23 percent. They would come from a portion of federal outlays known

SEE BUDGET ON A6

Resistance from GOP: Lawmakers balk at approving DOGE’s cuts. A6

Downsizing planned at intelligence agencies

Thousands of positions would be eliminated, including 1,200 at CIA

BY WARREN P. STROBEL

The Trump administration is planning significant personnel cuts at the Central Intelligence Agency and other major U.S. spy units, downsizing the government’s most sensitive national security agencies, according to people familiar with the plans.

The administration recently informed lawmakers on Capitol Hill that it intends to reduce the CIA’s workforce by about 1,200 personnel over several years and cut thousands more from other parts of the U.S. intelligence community, including at the National Security Agency, a highly secretive service that specializes in cryptology and global electronic espionage, a person familiar with the matter said. The person, like others interviewed, spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive matters.

The specifics of the planned cuts have not been previously reported.

The CIA does not publicly disclose the size of its workforce, but it is believed to be about 22,000. It is unclear which parts of the spy agency would be most affected. The downsizing is happening

SEE CUTS ON A12

IN THE NEWS

Aid ship under fire Organizers said a vessel carrying humanitarian assistance for Gaza was hit by armed drones off Malta, causing serious damage to its hull. A11

Think local Takoma Park, Md., is working with an artisan to use existing wood from felled trees as part of a library expansion. B1

THE NATION **Arizona’s bungled** effort to require voters to prove citizenship signals hurdles for the GOP. A3 **An HHS report** casting doubt on gender transition care for trans youth got fierce pushback. A7

THE WORLD **The U.S.** trade war is but one issue weighing on today’s federal elections in Australia. A10 **Britain’s right-wing** Reform U.K. Party celebrated key wins in local elections. A11

THE ECONOMY **A \$50 sweater** may now become an \$80 sweater under new policies on trade with China, Shira Ovide writes. A13 **The 177,000 jobs** added in April were a welcome surprise for the U.S. economy amid tariff uncertainty. A14

THE REGION **Six Flags America** is set to close, which is another blow to Prince George’s County’s business aspirations. B1 **Tennessee police** released video from a 2022 traffic stop of wrongfully deported Maryland man Kilmar Abrego García. B1

STYLE **The director of “Rust”** talks about finishing the film after a tragic on-set shooting death. C1 **SPORTS** **The return** of Aliaksei Protas from a skate blade cut on his foot has provided a shot in the arm for the Capitals in the NHL playoffs. D1

BUSINESS NEWS.....A13
COMICS.....C5
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A15
TELEVISION.....C4
WORLD NEWS.....A10

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54205

